

WORD SQUARES

With the exception of the following example, the Word Square is undoubtedly a modern invention.

ROTAS
OPERA
TENET
AREPO
SATOR

This has come down to us from ancient times and in the latter half of the last century, at Cirencester (the Roman Corinium), a fragment of wall plaster was dug up bearing in rustic Roman capitals this inscription. It is also a Palindrome, reading "Rotas, Opera, Tenet, Arepo, Sator" backwards or forwards, but unfortunately the sentence has no meaning for us, since the word Arepo is not known to exist. Yet a free translation might be, "The sower Arepo keeps the wheels at work." This square was, in old days, supposed to have magical value.

The compiler of the present book believes that he was the first, about 1890, to introduce Word Squares in verse. The following is an example that is pretty well-known:—

127. The Abbey

'Twas spring. The abbey woods were decked with
second.

Dmitri Borgmann, in *Language on Vacation* (Scribners, 1965), p. 193, agrees. He gives some superb examples of order-7 word squares (pp. 180-182), eight of the best order-8 squares (pp. 193-194), and, *mirabile dictu*, three order-9 squares (p. 195).
—M.G.